

THE SLIGHT EDGE

Turning Simple Disciplines into Massive Success

JEFF OLSEN



The Big "So What"

The Slight Edge is a philosophy, a new way of thinking, to help us to make simple daily choices and take small actions, that create the compound effect to deliver the lives we desire. If you are prepared to start with just one simple, daily discipline and consistently apply the 7 Slight Edge principles, you can turn around any aspect of your life in just a few years.



Introduction

We already have all the information about success that we need. The book is about applying that information in our daily lives. The book starts with a few relatable stories to illustrate the principles of the Slight Edge at work all around us. The Slight Edge is about knowing that the small things we do – even when people are not watching – add up to create massive positive or negative outcomes in our lives. It is about consistently making the right choices every day.



THE SLIGHT EDGE

The Secret Ingredient

Our philosophies shape our attitudes, actions and results, which in turn shape our lives. The Slight Edge is a philosophy; it represents a way of thinking: what we know, how we hold that knowledge, and what we do. The secret ingredient is straightforward: to do the small things over and over again until success kicks in. Most of these small things are extremely easy to do—such as choosing between a salad or a packet of French

KEY QUOTES

"There is no magic bullet, quick fix, or quantum leap method to reach success... (the Slight Edge) is a philosophy that will become a filter for every decision you make. It will give you a way to apply great information into your life in a way that will produce lasting results."

"The things you do every day, the things that don't look like they matter, do matter. They not only make a difference – they make all the difference."

"The single most important thing I can tell you about the Slight Edge is this: it's already working, right now, either for you or against you. So don't wait."

fries, saving a penny or spending a penny. Yet, compounded over time, they can produce massive results.



Putting Time on Your Side

"Consistently repeated daily actions + time = unconquerable results"

A penny, doubled every day, will grow to over \$10 million in just one month. If you improved in an area by just 1% a day, you would have improved by 365% in 1 year. **With each passing minute and each new choice that we make, the Slight Edge is at work – either for us or against us.** Once you embrace this philosophy, you will know that if you do something long enough, you will get the results you want. But if you make the small errors of judgment long enough, you will also suffer the consequences.



If it's so simple, why doesn't everyone do it?



Things that are easy to do are just as easy not to do. Precisely because they are small decisions and actions, it won't kill us immediately if we don't do them today. A simple, positive action (e.g. exercising 30 minutes a day), repeated over time, adds up. A simple, negative action (e.g. eating a packet of potato chips), repeated over time, also adds up. But they are easy not to do.



Plant-Cultivate-Harvest: Everything goes through the plant-cultivate-harvest cycle – this requires the seeds to be planted, and time for them to grow. For the slight edge to work, you can't start with nothing. **You have to at least start with a penny, a seed, i.e. you have to do something. Then, you have to keep doing it until you succeed.** However, many people either expect something from nothing, or they want to go directly from plant to harvest.

KEY QUOTES

"How long will it take? Chances are it will take longer than you want it to....and when the time arrives, you'll be astonished at how quick it seemed."

"Here's the problem: every action that is easy to do, is also easy not to do."

"You plant, then you cultivate, and finally you harvest. Plan, cultivate, harvest. In today's world, everyone wants to go directly from plant to harvest."



The results are not immediately visible. The small activities are undramatic and seemingly insignificant. You don't get immediate results or feedback, and no one notices you making the small choices daily. By the time they notice your results, the work has already been done.

As a society, we tend to worship breakthroughs and quantum leaps. This can be dangerous because there is actually no magic bullet that will propel us to success - **focusing on quantum leaps can prevent us from doing the small actions required to deliver results.**

The 7 Slight Edge Principles



Show up, even when others drop out.



Be consistent: Showing up consistently provides structure, in small doses that are easier to handle.



Have a good attitude: Bring energy and vitality, not criticism and negativity. Surround yourself with positive people, and stay away from the naysayers. Having said that, we will still have our "funky" moments when we don't feel good - embrace this as part and parcel of life that everyone goes through.



Be committed for a long period of time. Commit to principles 1-3 above, and give yourself time to build your attitudes and beliefs, knowing that the results will eventually come.



Have faith and a burning desire



Be willing to pay the price



Practice Integrity, i.e. do the little things even when no one is watching, and do the things you said you were going to do, long after the mood to do them has left you.

KEY QUOTES

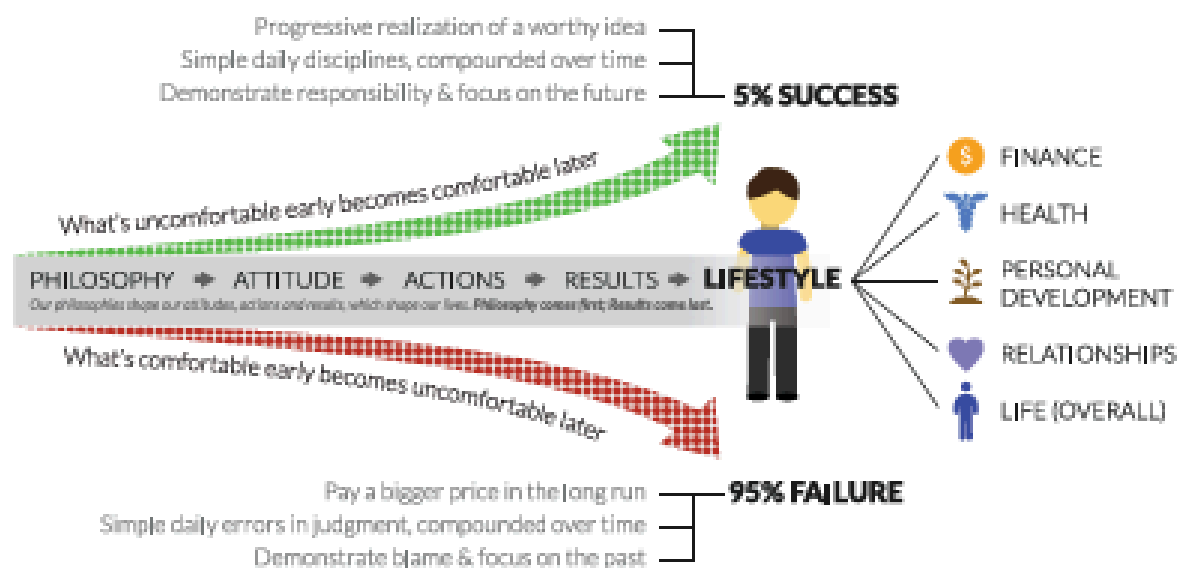
"It isn't that the actions are wrong. It's that people don't keep doing them."

"No success is immediate. Nor is any failure instantaneous. They are both products of the Slight Edge."

"The important point is to start on the path and to remember that no matter what has gone on before, you can begin fresh and new and at any time you can choose to start with a clean slate."

Two Life Paths

It has been scientifically established that space is curved. There are no such things as straight lines – everything, including your life, is curved. Your daily choices determine which curve you are on. If you are making the right choices every day, your life curve is on the upper half (which only 5% of people are on). If you are making simple errors in judgment daily, you are on the lower curve (where the majority of people are).



- **The Upper Curve:** Those on the upper curve **demonstrate responsibility** – they accept that they alone are the cause of where they are; they do not find excuses, nor do they attach any judgment of right or wrong to the situation. They **focus on the future**, and use the past merely as tools to pull themselves forward.
- **The Lower Curve:** Those on the lower curve **demonstrate blame** – they blame themselves, others and the external environment for their circumstances. They tend to **focus on the past** with regret, remorse or retributions.

If we take an honest look at what we are doing daily in different aspects of our lives – our health, personal development, relationships, finances, and life itself (our impact and legacy) – we will know if we are on the upward or downward curve.

The good news is, the past doesn't equate the future. The Slight Edge is constantly at work; **once you make a firm decision to step onto the upper curve and consistently apply the 7 Slight Edge principles, you can turn any area of your life around in a few years.** In fact, genuine success in any one area of your life tends to spread to other areas.

KEY QUOTES

"As you walk your path, it is always, every moment of every day, curving either upward or downward."

"Responsibility starts with...the point of view...that you are the source of what you are, what you do and what you have." - Werner Erhard

"Failure, unchecked by a choice to change, is a life-long condition."

"Success in any one of these areas begin to affect all the others, too. Improve your health and you improve your relationships; work on your personal development and you have an impact on your career. Everything affects everything else."

Mastering Your Life

Mastery is a state of mind, not an end-goal or destination. Babies learning to walk never think of quitting, nor do they tell themselves “I’m not cut out for it” after a few failed attempts. We were all babies once – we just need to remember that childlike willingness to keep trying, and get back on the path of mastery.

Closing the Gap

When we want something, we both desire it and lack it. A natural tension is created between Point A (where we are) and Point B (where we could be). That gap will somehow be resolved. The question is whether we resolve it by moving Point B closer to Point A (i.e. we compromise or give up on our dreams) or we move Point A closer to Point B (i.e. we overcome our problems). The bigger a person's life, the bigger the problems that he/she faces.

When we have a strong vision or desire, we feel uncomfortable. We also make others around us uncomfortable, because we remind them of their own gaps. That is why we should be cautious who we share our goals with, as those without the right philosophies and attitudes will pull us down, out of self-defence.

Olsen shares that at a typical funeral, only ten people cry. Why live our entire lives worrying about what others thought, when only a handful of people will even care or remember us when we are gone? People who are remembered by the masses are those who dared to do what they believed in, regardless of what others thought.

Harnessing The Power of The Slight Edge

 **The power of momentum:** Activity is important because once you are in motion, you are harnessing the power of momentum to keep going; Once you stop, it is harder to get started again. Allow yourself to move at your optimal rate, from slow to fast.

KEY QUOTES

“Mastery is the act of setting your foot on the path.”

“You gave up on the universal truth that simple little disciplines, done again and again over time, would move the biggest mountains.”

“Noticing that you’re not where you want to be can be uncomfortable. Wanting hurts.”

“You can measure the impact a person’s life has by the size of the problems he or she solves.”

“Gigantic funerals are held and great crowds, sometimes entire nations, mourn for those people who spent their lives not worrying about what others thought.”



The power of completion: Each time we complete something (e.g. fulfill a promise to take the kids somewhere, say “I’m sorry”), we lighten our load of the past and improve our forward mobility. If we ignore our list of incompletions, the fear or inertia that kept us from completing the tasks in the first place will compound with time.



The power of habit: When we repeat something long enough, it becomes automatic and we do it without thinking. The Slight Edge is about taking the right simple actions, over and over again, so they form positive habits that serve you.



The power of reflection: Being busy doesn't necessarily mean being productive. Reflect daily on what you are doing, so improvement becomes second nature.



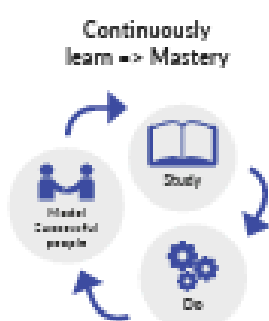
The power of celebration: Catch yourself doing something right, and celebrate each successful right choice.

Results Come Last

Our results are a function of what we have done in the past. Focusing on results means focusing on the past. To focus on the future, we need to look at controlling our thoughts (which determine our attitudes and actions), which are in turn determined by our philosophy. In short, **we must start with the right philosophy to life.**

Continuous Learning

Invest in your personal development, as learning is a key element of the Slight Edge philosophy. There are 3 key ways to learn:



- **Learn by study**
- **Learn by doing**
- **Learn through modelling:** Find people who have achieved what you want to achieve, surround yourselves with them, and emulate their success.

KEY QUOTES

"Your optimal rate of growth is always served best by a step-by-step approach of constant, never-ending improvement, which lays solid foundations and builds upon them over and over."

Every incomplete promise, commitment and agreement saps your strength... Incomplete things keep calling you back to the past to take care of them."

"The only reliable, consistent way to control your attitudes is to control your thoughts. And the source of your thoughts is your philosophy."

"Your philosophy comes first; your results come last."

"Life is not a spectator sport – it is a contact sport; there is no practice session."

The learning process involves developing an awareness of yourself and what is contributing versus hindering your progress. It requires a balance between being book-smart and street-smart, and it inherently involves a constant process of course-correction and plan-do-review.

Turning Your Dreams Into Reality

There are 4 foundational steps to goal setting:

- **Write it down:** Envision it, make it specific with all your senses, and give it a deadline.
- **Start with a plan:** Know that the plan is only our jump-off point. There is no such thing as a perfect plan; the plan that we start with will not be the same plan that brings us success. However, we need to start with our first plan in order to take our first steps, start the learning journey and refine our course.
- **Understand and pay the price:** There will be a price to pay for success, e.g. giving up the right to be right, giving up a few hours of television. In the long run, the price of doing what you should will always be smaller than the price of not doing it.
- **Look at it everyday.**

Living The Slight Edge

Olsen takes us through 5 key areas of our lives, including health, personal development, relationships, finances, and life in general. For each of these areas, list down the following:



My dreams for this area (be specific, vivid, with a deadline)



Price to pay



Plan to Start



One simple daily discipline

KEY QUOTES

"Whatever price you pay, there's a bigger price to pay for not doing it than the price for doing it. The price of neglect is much worse than the price of discipline."

"All the information you need is already out there – and, right here. You're already doing the actions. All you need to do is choose to have them serve and empower you – and keep on choosing."